this imperial construct serves today as the capital of the Republic of India. It is *amusing* that, after independence, over-fed politicians feigning poverty in their white kurta-pyjamas would come to occupy the spacious bungalows meant for the ‘fat white’.

A lot has been written about the grand buildings and bungalows of Lutyens’s Delhi. However, if one looks at early photographs of the cityscape in the 1920s and 1930s, it looks very different from what we see today. It is not just that much of the city is a construction zone, but even the completed bits look somehow naked. On second glance one realizes that the difference is that the trees that we now associate with the city have not yet grown. Indeed, the systematic and careful planting of trees was a very important part of the overall design and remains a signature feature of the national capital.

The systematic planning of trees was not new in Delhi. At its height, Shahjehanabad (Old Delhi) had several private Mughal gardens belonging to the royal family and senior nobility. This included the Begum Jehanara’s gardens north of Chandni Chowk and the two famous gardens within the Red Fort—Hayat Baksh (Life-Giver) and Mahtab Bagh (Moonlit Garden). The British, however, took this to a totally different level as they tried to create a garden city. There are archival records of heated debates between foresters, horticulturists and civil servants about the ideal species to be planted. Finally the Town Planning Committee submitted a report in 1913 with a list of thirteen trees including neem, jamun and imli that were considered suitable for planting along the avenues of New Delhi. [25] Other species would be introduced in later times, but trees from the original shortlist still dominate many of the roads of Lutyens’s Delhi.

The colonial town-planners also invested heavily in reforesting the Aravalli ridges around New Delhi, particularly the Central Ridge just behind Rashtrapati Bhavan. The principal tree that was used for this was the Central American mesquite or ‘vilayati keekar’ that would become a very common tree in Delhi. People tend to confuse it with the local keekar or babool but, in fact, it is an invasive species that has edged out many of the